Isolated military outposts were overrun. Roads were rendered unusable by a number of ambushes. In the cities, terrorist attacks were launched against the government's US military advisers, including bombings of American-frequented cinemas and clubs.

FIGHTING THE AMERICANS

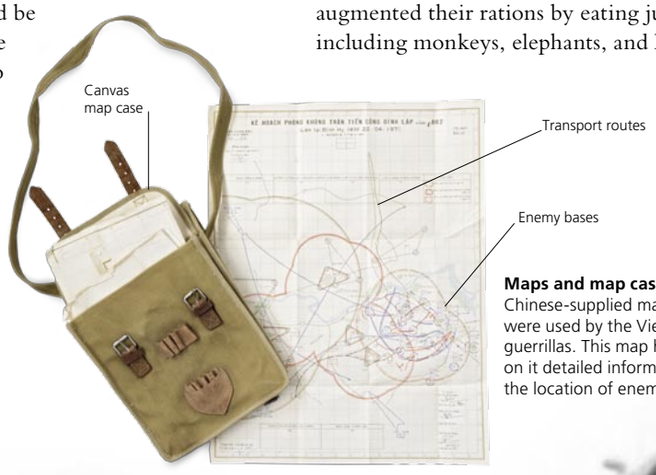
From 1965, the nature of the war changed radically. The United States sent in its armed forces to prevent the fall of the South Vietnamese government. At the same time, the North Vietnamese Army began sending troops into the South in large numbers. Although the guerrilla war of ambushes, booby traps, and assassinations continued, soon much of the war was being fought between US soldiers and North Vietnamese infantry or Viet Cong main force guerrillas in wild, largely deserted country. The Viet Cong proved to be a match for US ground forces as light infantrymen. Led by officers who shared their hardships, they moved swiftly across country, manoeuvred skilfully to carry out ambushes and encirclements, and hugged their enemy in firefights to inhibit close air support. US forces found them frustratingly elusive, filtering away before decisive defeat could be inflicted. But for the guerrillas, subject to bombing, shelling, napalm, and fire from fixed-wing and helicopter gunships, combat with the US forces was, above all, a gruelling ordeal in which they took heavy casualties.



Chinese compass
Much of the equipment used by the Viet Cong was provided by communist China. Compasses such as this were essential for orientation in the jungle.

FAR FROM HOME

The guerrilla's experience of war was characterized by fear, hardship, homesickness, and boredom. The jungle was no more a familiar habitat to peasants from the rice paddies than it was to the Americans. To the Vietnamese, the jungle-clad mountains were a place to be feared, inhabited as they were by ghosts and fearsome wild animals. They suffered terribly from malaria and from snakebites – the guerrillas' famous rubber sandals offered very poor protection against poisonous reptiles. Surviving mainly on small quantities of rice, salt, and dried fish or meat, the guerrillas were often in a state of semi-starvation. They augmented their rations by eating jungle fauna, including monkeys, elephants, and large moths



Maps and map case
Chinese-supplied map cases were used by the Viet Cong guerrillas. This map has marked on it detailed information about the location of enemy bases.

Guerrilla weapons
The Viet Cong used a wide variety of infantry weapons, many originating from the Soviet Union. Here guerrillas are equipped with a Korean War-vintage Goryunov 7.62mm heavy machine-gun, Simonov rifles, and state-of-the-art AK47 assault rifles.

